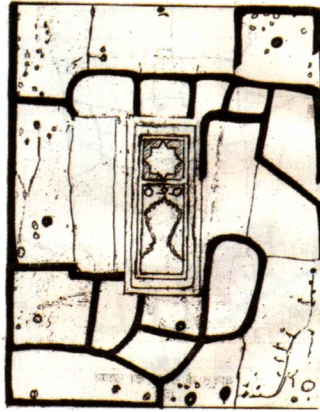




Unwritten EPITAPH

A grave in Rajasthan that many believe is Razia Sultan's could rewrite history

| By Rohit Parihar |

Most historians believe that legendary warrior queen Razia Sultan, the first woman ruler of Delhi and the Turk Sultanate 800 years ago, was killed along with her husband Malik Altunia by her brother Muizuddin Bahram Shah during a battle at Kaithal, and was buried at Delhi's Turkman Gate. A tomb exists there—a protected monument—with two graves, one of which is said to be that of Razia's sister. History records that Altunia, then governor of Bathinda, had captured Razia after killing her trusted general and paramour Jamaluddin Yaqut, an Abyssinian slave. The accepted version is that Razia then married Altunia and con-

tinued to rule before being dethroned by her own brother. The dispute was whether she was buried in Kaithal or not and also where were Altunia and Yaqut buried. Now, it appears that popular history may have been wrong.

There is now new evidence to suggest that Razia was actually buried hundreds of miles away in Tonk, Rajasthan. If true, that will require a rewrite of many accepted historical facts, not to mention romantic legend. The daughter of Sultan Iltutmish died at 35 and a recent claim that she was buried at Tonk, 100 km south of Jaipur, has alerted the Rajasthan Government to order protection of the site and further historical investigation. The site itself is authentic enough and dotted with Sultanate-era structures. The controversy and re-examination of historical facts arose after Sayed Sadique

Ali, an Urdu lecturer at the local government post-graduate college claimed that the graves at the site are that of Razia and her trusted slave, Yaqut. He based his findings on the calligraphic Arabic script deciphered by the pattern of stones of irregular shapes affixed around the graves. The stones convey a particular message which, according to him, is: "*Shahide Muhabbat Quvvatul-Mulk Jamaluddin Yaqut*" around the smaller grave, and on the main grave, situated at a higher level, it reads: "*Sultanul Hind Razia*." This, Ali, says is not due to the shifting of rocks and stones. "These are fixed patterns, fixed for centuries," he asserts. Ali admits that it is not easy to read the entire script at one go given the height of the platform.

His claim is backed by other experts. "The manner in which the